tink. — Design identity & implementation handoff

Status: HackTX design direction and working *visual prototype*, October 23, 2026
Working line: *Small signals. Big understanding.*
Audience: design, frontend, interaction, accessibility, and demo teams

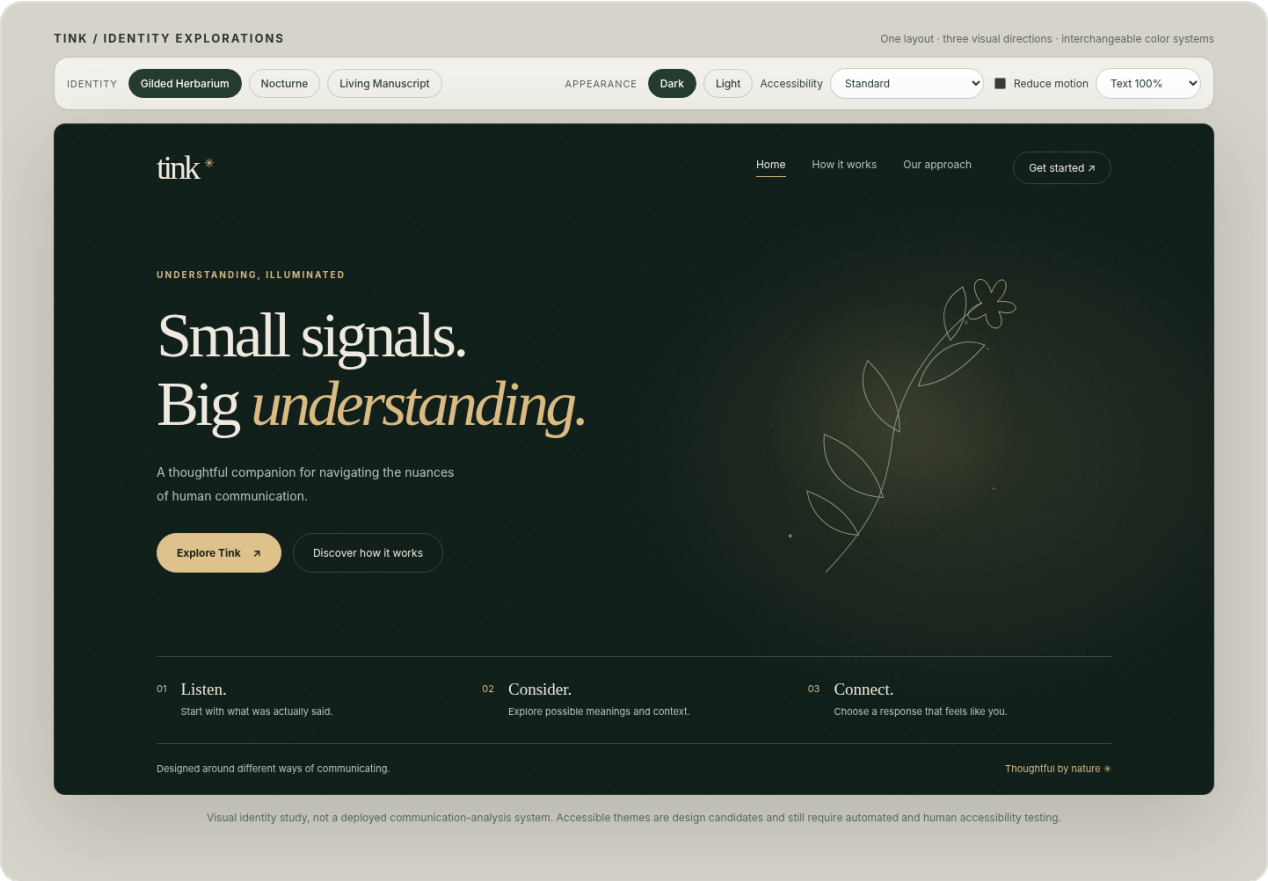
> ***North star:*** *Quiet magic. A premium, serene communication-assistance experience: carefully crafted like a luxury chocolate bar, not decorated like a fantasy game.*

1. Executive decision

Keep the name **tink.** and the established landing-page/application layout. Make the **Gilded Herbarium** the primary identity, with **Nocturne's** exceptionally restrained luminous effects and **Living Manuscript's** paper-like composure. Light/dark appearances are siblings, not separate websites. Accessibility preferences alter rendering without altering the core structure or task sequence. There are **no characters, fairies, silhouettes, wings as characters, or Tinker Bell depictions** in the final UI.

Tink's story connection is conceptual: small signals, delicate mechanisms, craftsmanship, illumination, and making subtle meaning visible. It should not resemble official Peter Pan/Disney branding, use a recognizable character silhouette, or depend on someone knowing the source material.

What must not happen: no forest photographs beneath body copy; no vines framing every card; no glowing outlines around every control; no hundreds of particles; no visual overload; no status conveyed by color alone; no claim that the interface can reliably read people's hidden intentions.



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2. The brand in one sentence

Tink makes complicated communication feel more approachable through calm, thoughtfully qualified interpretation. It is an assistive companion, not a mind-reading tool, clinical diagnostic device, or replacement for asking another person what they mean.

Brand attributes

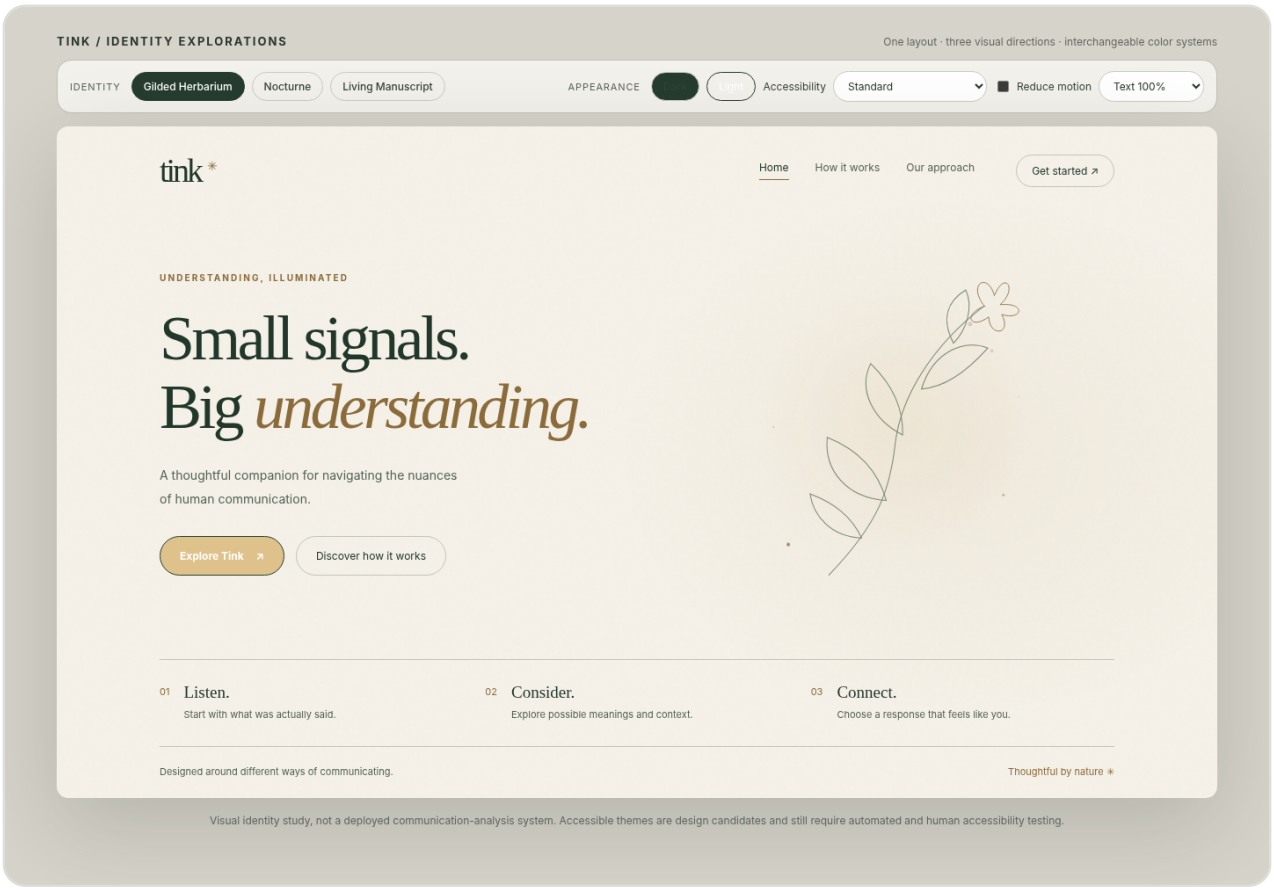
- **Precise:** clear language, traceable observations, confidence calibrated to evidence.
- **Tender:** reassuring without patronizing or infantilizing.
- **Crafted:** meticulous spacing, typography, interactions, and color transitions.
- **Quietly mystical:** little points of light and botanical linework, never spectacle.
- **Inclusive:** multiple input methods and accessible outputs; no diagnosis required to change settings.

Tone: short, warm, concrete, non-judgmental. Say “One possible reading…” rather than “They are definitely upset.” Avoid rigid emotion labels and diagnostic language. When uncertainty matters, show it visibly.

3. Three studies, one final identity

1. **Gilded Herbarium — primary.** Matte forest backgrounds, fine botanical engraving, ivory, sage and warm muted gold. The strongest link to premium confectionery or perfume packaging.
2. **Nocturne — selective inspiration.** One delicate light path or softly illuminated point. Useful for analysis transitions; do *not* inherit a whole starfield or neon-blue interface.
3. **Living Manuscript — structural inspiration.** Spacious page composition and paper-like warmth; particularly useful for light mode and long-form explanations.

The attached concept boards are **exploration artifacts, not production specifications**. Some contain busier treatments that have since been rejected. The **interactive HTML prototype and its screenshots** are the better reference for the restrained direction.



4. The recognizable signature

Create a single proprietary **illuminated filament** graphic: a fine line that can read as a plant stem, a thread of light, or a waveform. It is a metaphor for finding meaning in small signals.

- Brand use: one delicate filament in the hero artwork, terminating in one or two light points.
- Interaction use: its curve may respond *once* when a process successfully completes.
- Content use: convert it into a quiet waveform motif only when analysis is the active task.

- Reduced-motion use: identical, static silhouette with no lost information.
- Accessible use: purely decorative SVG should be hidden from screen readers; meaningful progress must have its own text.

Do **not** use a winged character, a fairy icon in the wordmark, or hundreds of twinkling points. A wordmark `tink.` in a high-quality serif (e.g., Fraunces or another appropriately licensed face) plus a small abstract spark/stem is enough. Prefer a legible UI sans-serif (e.g., Inter) for all dense text and controls. Do not use script fonts for functional interface copy.

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5. Visual rules and hierarchy

Composition: editorial first. Large text, short sentences, strong horizontal alignment, intentional empty space. Premium equals restraint and exactness, not darkness by itself.

Visual budget (directional, not a measurement): around 90% calm background, typography, and functional surfaces; about 10% botanical/light detailing. **One** hero focal ornament per screen, never multiple competing focal points.

Decoration rules:

- Only one botanical composition on a view, mostly on a page margin or far side of hero.
- At most approximately 3–6 static illumination points in the hero. Fewer in the app.
- In application views, illustrations should fade substantially or disappear; a single small motif can remain.
- Avoid gradients behind text, particle effects over interactive controls, strong drop shadows, and heavy glassmorphism.
- Use fine borders, matte surfaces, and subtle tonal elevation instead of floating stacks of cards.
- No imagery showing a fairy, personified pixie, silhouette, wings that read as an identifiable character, or Tinker Bell herself.

Spacing/type targets: 8px-based spacing scale; main desktop content width approximately 1120–1190px; generous hero padding; 16px body text default; body line-height 1.5–1.7; 12–16px typical card radii; comfortable touch targets. These are starting guidelines, not limits that should break responsive design.

Responsive: one layout and one content hierarchy across themes. On smaller screens the hero becomes stacked; ornamental art can shrink or be hidden. The primary CTA and critical text must remain usable on narrow viewports.

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6. Color and theme architecture

Appearance is distinct from accessibility. A user's choices must compose cleanly:

```
Theme configuration
├── appearance: system | light | dark
├── contrast: standard | high
├── color-vision palette: default | deuteranopia-friendly | protanopia-friendly | tritanopia-friendly
├── sensory: standard | low-stimulation
├── motion: system | reduced
├── typography: default | large | extra-large
└── comprehension: standard | simplified
```

The current prototype groups some accessibility combinations into one dropdown. That is useful for comparison but **the production implementation should expose independent settings**, with sensible conflict precedence (high contrast should override purely decorative accent choices). Presets for color-vision differences are *candidates* requiring testing with color-vision simulations and real people. Do not assert they are universally “safe.”

Starter design tokens

Token	Dark	Light
`surface.base`	`#101E19`	`#F5F1E8`
`surface.raised`	`#1B2B23`	`#EBE9DF`
`text.primary`	`#EEEAE0`	`#21372A`
`text.secondary`	`#B9C4B9`	`#526254`
`accent.decorative`	`#D9BB83`	`#8B6B3A`
`action.fill`	`#DFC28B`	`#244330`
`action.text`	`#18241D`	`#FFFFFF`
`botanical.line`	`#93A78E`	`#6C7E66`

These values reflect the **visual prototype**, not an approved contrast audit. Verify actual color combinations programmatically; ensure color is never the sole status channel. Use tokens, not hex colors hardcoded into components.

High contrast: near-black/white base pairs; strong focus indicators; no background glow or textures; preserve meaning and layout. **Low stimulation:** restrained palette, static visuals, no decorative particle animation, but maintain readable text contrast. **Color-vision modes:** use accessible contrast plus shapes/text/icons for every semantic state. Status may be `Observed`, `Possible`, `Uncertain` with labels and distinct symbols; never green/orange/purple alone.

Example CSS organization

```
:root { --surface: #f5f1e8; --text: #21372a; --action: #244330; --action-text: #fff; }
[data-appearance="dark"] { --surface: #101e19; --text: #eeeae0; --action: #dfc28b; --action-text: #18241d; }
[data-contrast="high"][data-appearance="dark"] { --surface: #000; --text: #fff; --action: #ffe36d; --action-text:
```

```
#000; }
.button-primary { background: var(--action); color: var(--action-text); }
@media (prefers-reduced-motion: reduce) { *, *::before, *::after { scroll-behavior: auto !important; animation-
duration: 0.01ms !important; } }
```

Persist explicit user preferences locally with consent-aware application storage; “system” should follow OS preferences. Avoid a flash of the wrong theme on first render. Make resets easy. No theme may reorder primary buttons, remove critical content, or change the route through the app.

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7. Page-specific direction

A. Marketing hero

Keep the existing split layout: wordmark/navigation, “Small signals. Big understanding.”, a two-line description, primary/secondary CTA, and **one** exquisite botanical filament illustration opposite the text. Below the fold: **Listen / Consider / Connect** as a sparse three-step row separated by hairlines—not large icon cards.

No: character renders, jungle backgrounds, dense flower borders, feature-card walls, particle overlays.

B. Input/analysis

One clear focal task: *Start with a conversation.* Let people enter text with no microphone or camera required. Later allow audio, video and live modes as optional, permissioned extensions. No automatic recording; clearly mark microphone/camera state and provide pause/stop.

Sample mode must be obviously labeled as a demonstration. The provided HTML only implements a **text example** and a predetermined interpretation, **not an AI model**. It intentionally does not record, upload, or analyze actual audio/video.

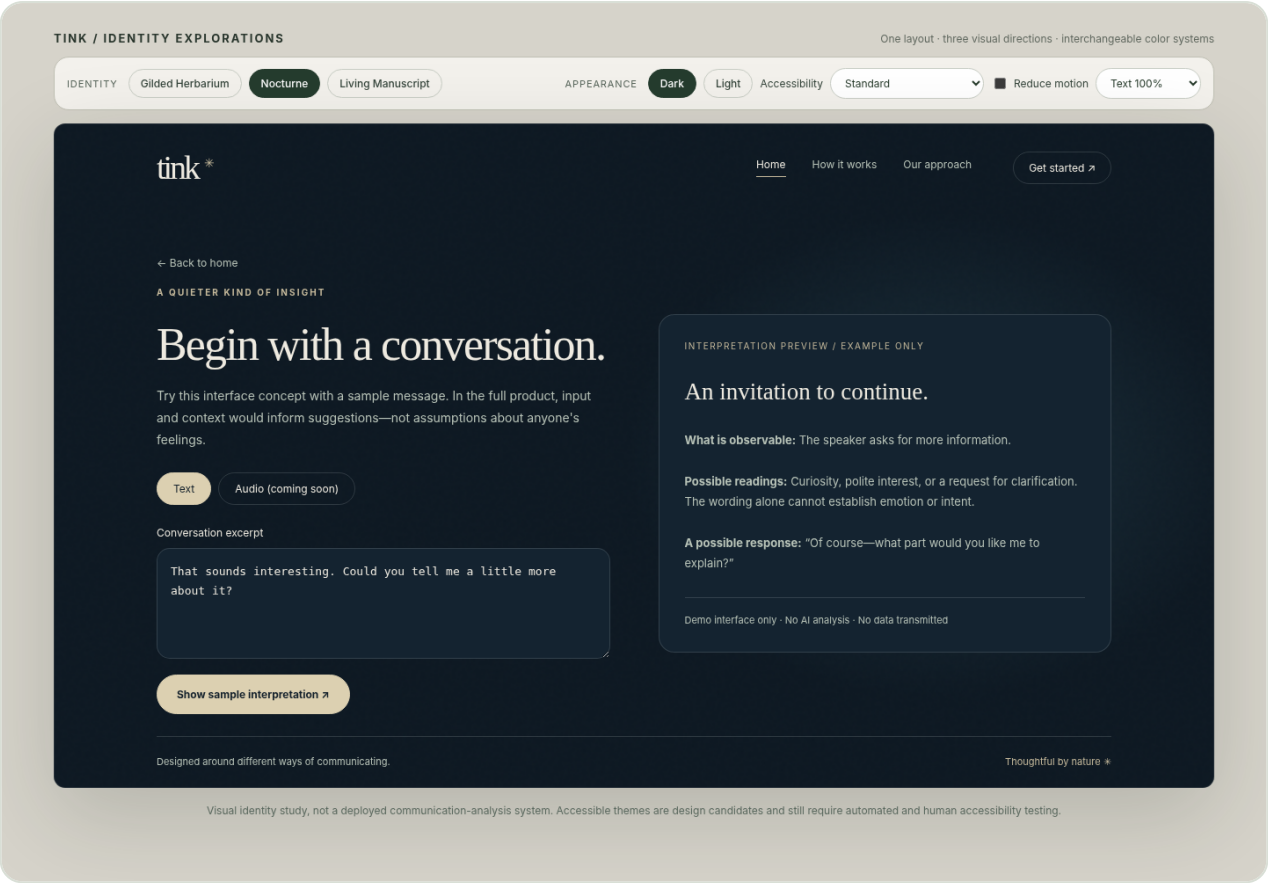
C. Results

Use hierarchy: **what is observed → possible interpretations → uncertainty / alternatives → useful response suggestion**. Separate evidence from speculation. Example: “The speaker asked for more information” (observed); “They may be curious or requesting clarification” (possible); “Text alone does not confirm emotion” (limitation); “You could ask what they’d like to know” (action).

Avoid “72% positive” unless a defensible model is actually calibrated, evaluated, and adequately explained. Prefer evidence-backed uncertainty to ornamental percentages. The results need text-first presentation that can be read aloud by assistive technology.

D. Preferences/accessibility

Place accessible theme controls in a persistent settings area, and a small appearance shortcut in the header. Organize into Appearance, Reading/Comprehension, Motion/Sensory, Input/Media, Language, and Privacy. Every option should be available without disclosing a disability.



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8. Accessibility acceptance criteria

Target **WCAG 2.2 AA** as a development goal, *not* as an achieved certification. Verify at least:

- 4.5:1 contrast for normal text and 3:1 for applicable large text and meaningful non-text elements.
- Keyboard-only use for all functionality; visible 3:1 focus indication against adjacent colors where applicable; no focus traps.
- Semantic HTML, correctly named controls, meaningful headings and landmarks, logical focus order; screen-reader testing (NVDA/VoiceOver).
- At least WCAG 2.2 AA minimum target sizing (24×24 CSS pixels or applicable exceptions); aim for larger primary actions.
- Reflow at narrow equivalent widths and up to 400% zoom; readable text at 200% resize without clipped controls.
- Respect reduced-motion settings; avoid flashing; no autoplay decorative motion; no essential information encoded in animation.
- Captions/transcripts for any actual audio/video functions, with permission controls and clear recording indicator.
- Color-independent semantic states, discernible controls and error recovery; descriptive, understandable labels.

- Low-stimulation and simplified presentation that do not omit required information.
- Testing with assistive technologies and users with diverse needs, not only automated audit tools.

Recommended QA matrix: desktop light/dark, mobile light/dark, high contrast in each, each color-vision preset in each, low-stimulation, 200% text, 400% zoom, keyboard-only, NVDA or VoiceOver, and browser/system reduced-motion. Check all key screens, not just the landing page.

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9. Interaction language and motion

Motion rule: a visual cue must serve a purpose. 120–240ms hover/focus shifts are appropriate when they are nonessential; some users should see no movement. Add only a few fixed firefly-like lights in the hero and optionally one quiet light sweep on completed actions. Avoid looping sparkles in the analysis workspace.

Iconography: thin, consistent line icons. Neutral abstract spark or stem for brand; practical UI icons only when accompanied by labels in major navigation. Do not turn the cursor into a fairy or give the user an animated companion to manage.

Microcopy samples:

- “Begin with a conversation.”
- “Here’s what can be observed.”
- “A few possible interpretations.”
- “What we can’t tell from this alone.”
- “One response you could try.”
- “No recording begins until you choose Start.”

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10. Build order for HackTX

Priority 0 — reliable demo story. Pick a defensible text-based scenario that works reliably in front of judges. Show the user selecting a preferred theme and receiving a cautious interpretation of observed text. Make the product purpose clear immediately.

Priority 1 — foundations. Component styles, semantic tokens, light/dark, responsive landing/input/results shell, well-labeled text input, keyboard navigation, consent boundaries.

Priority 2 — inclusion. High-contrast themes, reduced motion, text scale, caption/transcript path if media exists, color-independent semantic states, preferences persistence, screen-reader QA.

Priority 3 — core inference (if implemented). Input processing, evidence vs interpretation separation, alternatives, uncertainty, optional feedback. Consider fairness, generalization across expression styles/languages, privacy and consent; do not promise emotion-reading accuracy without testing.

Priority 4 — one signature flourish. Refine the illuminated filament as an SVG, then add just one subtle transition. Refuse ornamental scope creep until the product is functional and accessible.

Priority 5 — judge rehearsal. Show the same layout in dark, light, high contrast, and low-stimulation. Demonstrate text-only operation and control without color or animation. Explain user needs carefully without claiming to represent populations that were not studied.

Demo narrative (about 90 seconds)

1. “We built Tink to help people explore the ambiguity of communication, not guess hidden emotions.”
2. Switch dark to light: same layout, no retraining or separate site.
3. Switch high contrast or reduced motion, then navigate using the keyboard.
4. Enter a safe sample sentence and show observation, alternatives, uncertainty and a suggested clarification.
5. End: “Communication is nuanced. The UI should be accessible even before the model makes a suggestion.”

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11. Prototype inventory and exact limitations

Open: `prototype/index.html` in a modern browser. It is a single-file standalone concept; no build system or network connection is required.

The prototype includes three identity buttons (Gilded Herbarium / Nocturne / Living Manuscript), dark/light, contrast/color-vision/low-stimulation **visual presets**, a reduce-motion control, 100%/112%/125% text scaling, a responsive layout, and a demo text interpretation. The visual presets are *not verified accessible palettes*; zoom, keyboard and screen-reader tests are still needed. No backend, microphone capture, camera capture, AI inference, deployed authentication, multilingual inference, or saved user profile is implemented.

Files

- `prototype/index.html` — source; open locally.
- `prototype/preview-dark.png` — recommended primary visual benchmark.
- `prototype/preview-light.png` — same structure in light mode.
- `prototype/preview-nocturne.png` — lighting-direction comparison.
- `prototype/preview-analysis.png` — actual text-demo interaction screen.
- `prototype/preview-mobile.png` — responsive sample.
- `reference-concepts/01-minimal-luxury-exploration.png` — later moodboard; not production specification.
- `reference-concepts/02-theme-architecture-exploration.png` — later high-level theme explorations; ornamental density is not a target.

- `reference-concepts/03-interface-exploration.png` — later UI concept visual; use as inspiration, not the current feature inventory.

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12. Design review checklist — pass/fail

- Can someone identify the primary task in three seconds?
- Does the page retain its hierarchy when all artwork, motion and color accents are removed?
- Are there fewer than two competing visual focal points?
- Is every magic detail intentional, not a repeated sticker?
- Is the content fully legible with font scaling and narrow reflow?
- Do semantic states remain understandable in grayscale and to screen readers?
- Does theme switching preserve exactly the same workflow?
- Are there zero recognizable fairy/Disney/Peter Pan character depictions?
- Do examples distinguish observable signals from interpretations and limitations?
- Is the demo truthful about which features actually work?

Final creative recommendation: Build the Gilded Herbarium system; adopt a single illuminated filament from Nocturne, and the generous editorial spacing of Living Manuscript. *Less fantasy illustration, more visual craftsmanship.*